Red Pen for WordPress

User manual - review notes pinned to the pages and elements of your WordPress site.

Version 0.29.0 · October 2026 · by Lincoln Tracy · redpen.tools

What Red Pen does

While you look at your site, you leave typed notes on the things they're about: "swap this header photo" pinned to the image, "should this button scroll instead?" pinned to the button. Notes live in a panel on the front end, show as numbered pins on the page, and collect in one repository in wp-admin. Clients can leave feedback through a private link with no WordPress login, and the whole pile prints to a clean report.

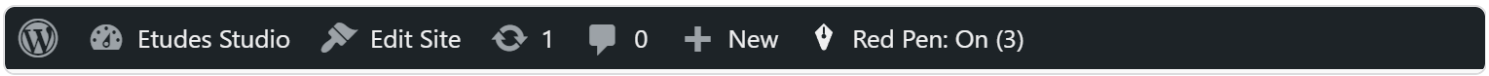
Everything stays in your WordPress database. No accounts, no external service, nothing leaves your site.

Install and activate

Plugins > Add New > Upload Plugin, choose the Red Pen zip, activate. That's it - one self-contained plugin file, no configuration required. You'll find the repository under **Tools > Red Pen** and a new entry in the admin bar.

Dev Mode

Red Pen stays invisible until you switch it on. The admin bar gets a **Red Pen: On/Off** entry with the count of open notes - click it to toggle. Dev Mode is per-user: your editors see the overlay only when they've turned it on, and visitors never see anything.

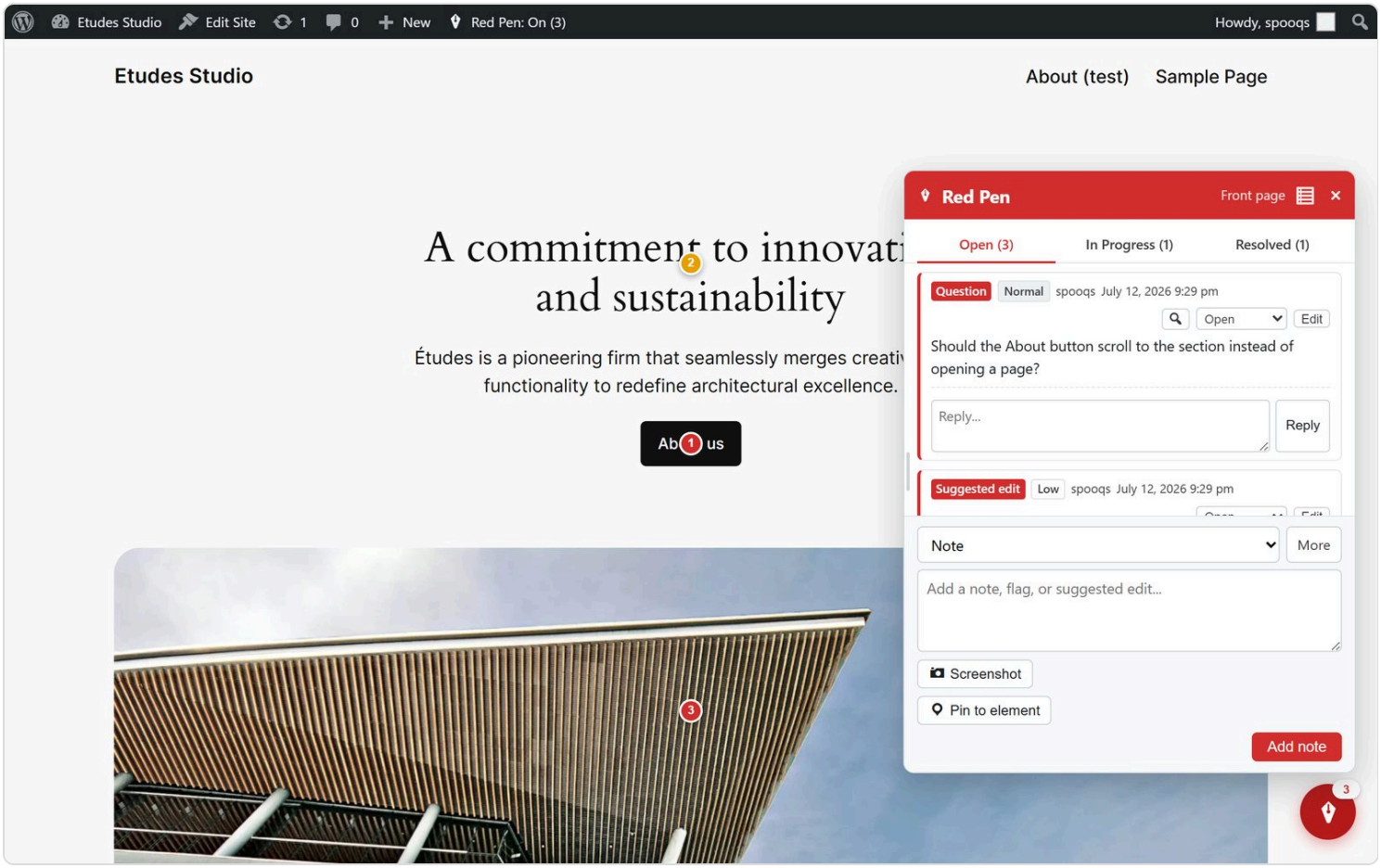


The admin-bar toggle, with the open-note count. Its submenu jumps to the repository, and "J" jumps to the next open note on the page.

Leaving a note

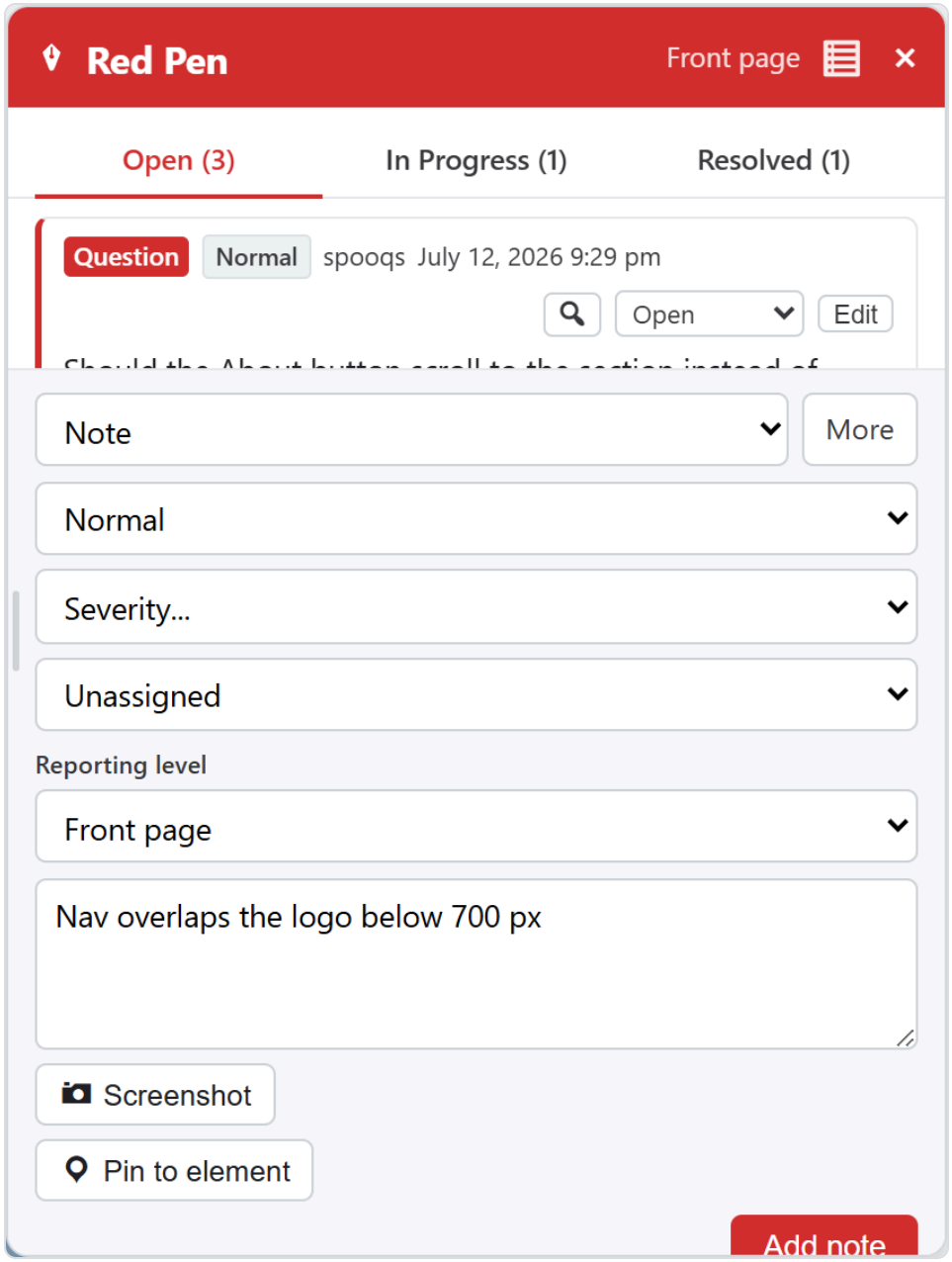
With Dev Mode on, a red pen button sits in the corner of every page. Click it and the panel opens: pick a type (Note, Idea, Problem, Question - or your own custom types), write the note, add it. **Pin to element** lets you click the exact thing on the page the note is about - it becomes a numbered pin, labelled with the element's own visible text (or its alt, aria-label or title, or a plain-language name for the tag) so "Pinned to Book a call" tells you what you aimed at. **Screenshot** captures the page state alongside the note.

Pin mode works on a phone. The page scrolls normally while the picker is open; a deliberate tap places the pin and a drag is treated as a scroll. The picker also carries a visible **Cancel** control, for devices with no Esc key.

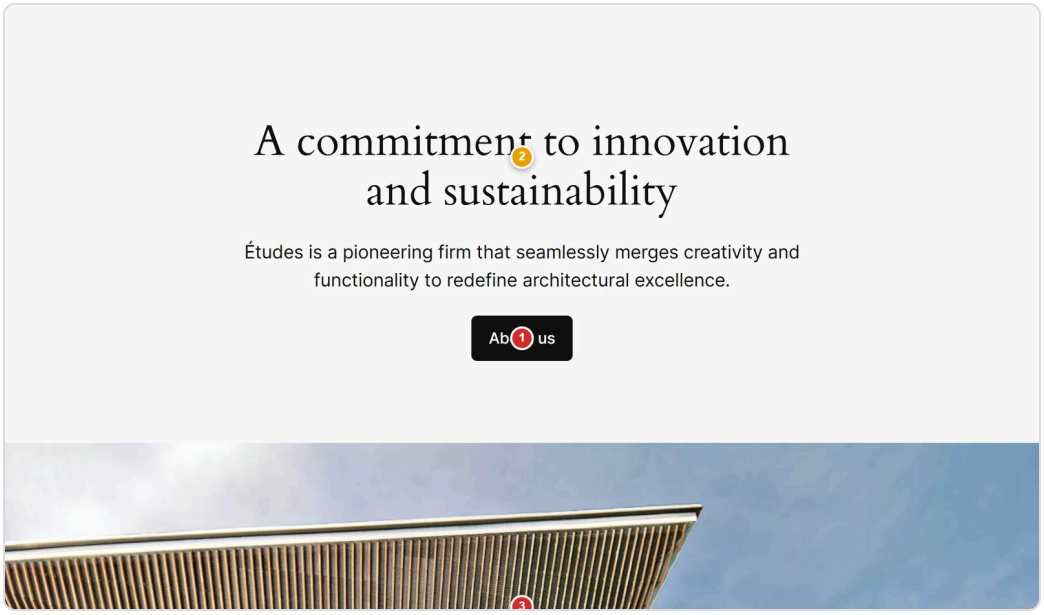


The panel over a page. Numbered pins mark element-anchored notes; the tabs split Open, In Progress, and Resolved.

The **More** drawer holds the rest: priority, severity, an assignee (a teammate - or an AI agent queue, if enabled), the reporting level, which controls whether the note belongs to this page, this template, or the whole site, and the **Visible to client reviewers** checkbox - off by default, and covered under Client review links below.



The More drawer: priority, severity, assignee, reporting level, screenshot and pin.



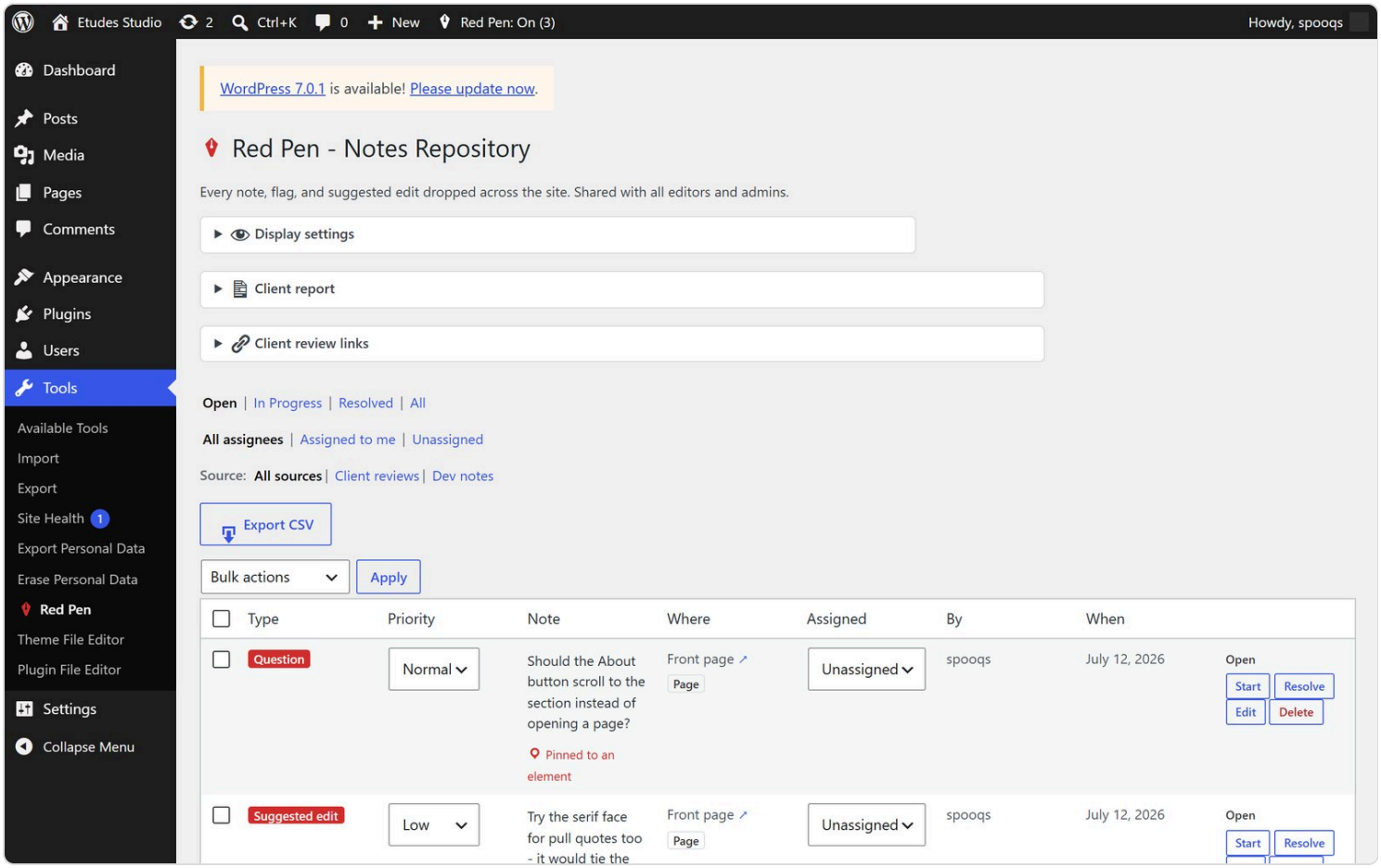
Pins land on the elements the notes are about.

Statuses, priorities, and replies

Every note is **Open**, **In Progress**, or **Resolved** - the panel's three tabs. Each note carries a priority, an optional severity, and its own reply thread, so the back-and-forth about a note stays on the note.

The repository

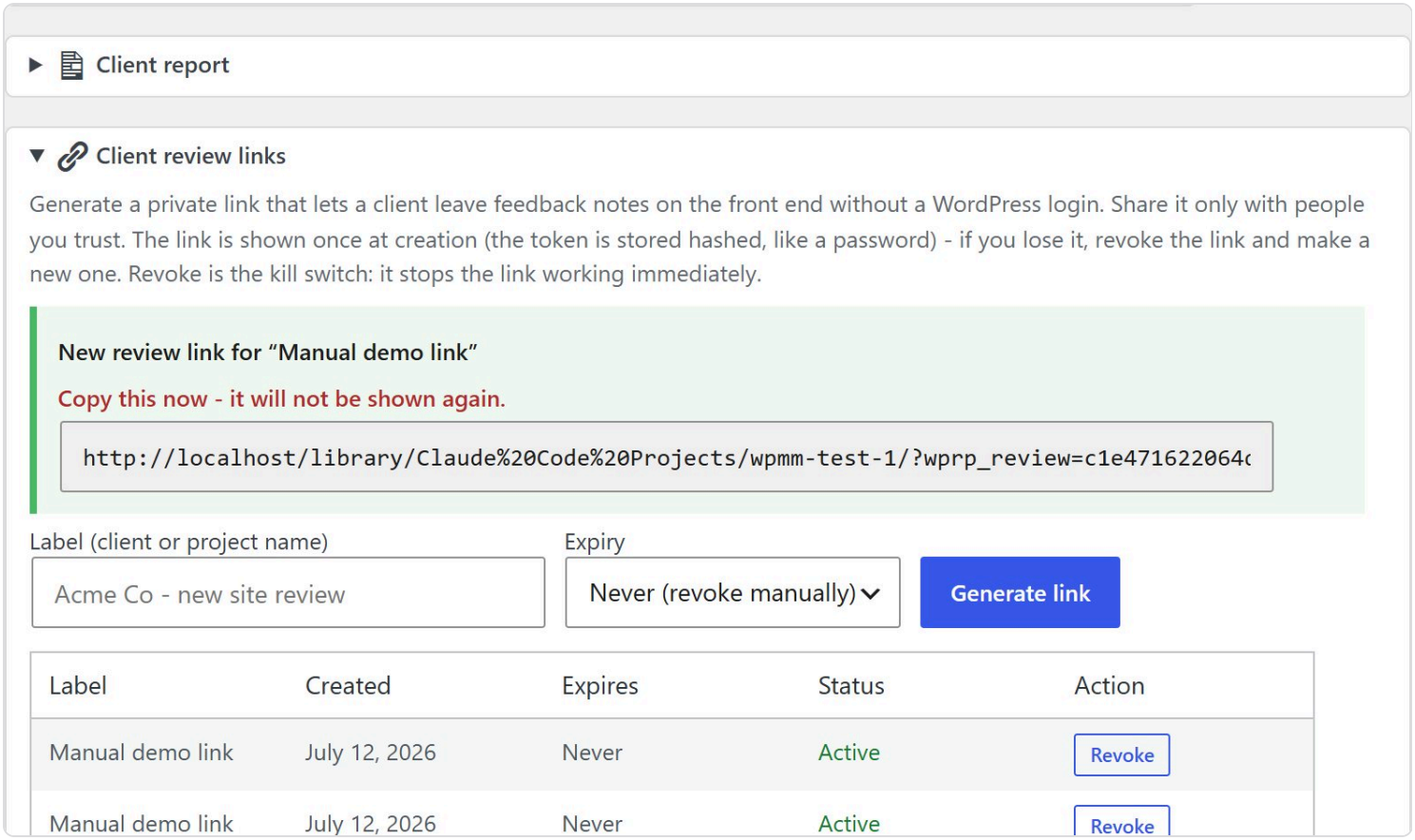
Tools > Red Pen lists every note across the site: filter by status, assignee, or source (client reviews vs dev notes), change priority or assignment inline, resolve or delete, use bulk actions, or export the lot to CSV (which carries a Client visible column). The three panels above the list hold Display settings, the Client report, and Client review links. Display settings and the report's branding are shown to administrators only, because they change things for the whole site.



The notes repository under Tools, with filters, bulk actions and CSV export.

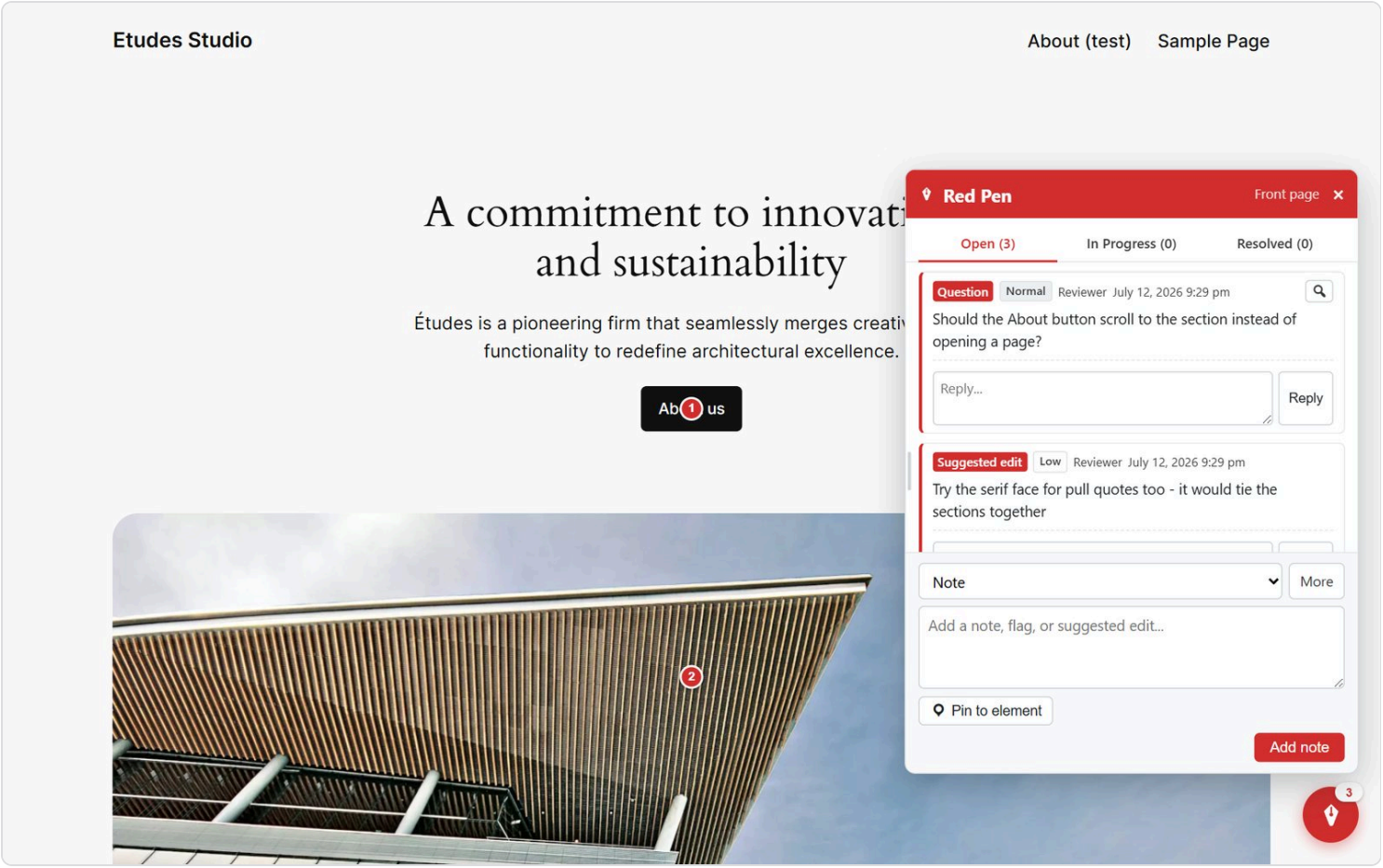
Client review links

Generate a private link and your client can leave notes on the live site with **no WordPress login**. The link is shown once at creation - the token is stored hashed, like a password - and Revoke kills it instantly. Links can expire on a schedule or live until revoked.



Generating a review link. Copy it at creation - it is not shown again.

A link holder gets a deliberately narrow version of the panel: they can read the notes shared with them, write notes, pin, reply, and edit or delete their own notes while those are still Open. No resolving, no admin access, no screenshots, no user lists. The boundary is enforced on the server, and reviewer submissions are rate-limited.



What the client sees through a review link: notes and pins, none of the controls.

When a client adds a note or a reply, the panel tells them it was saved and that the website team can see it. Before 0.29.0 the only sign was the note turning up in the list, which is easy to miss for someone using the panel for the first time. Replies from you or anyone else logged in to the site show to the client as **Website team**, and your own name never reaches a review link. In your own panel, a client's note carries the name they typed on it, where it used to say Unknown.

A link that has expired or been switched off tells the client so on the page, and tells them to ask you for a new one. Before 0.29.0 the site opened with no panel and no explanation, which looked like a broken site.

What a reviewer can see (changed in 0.26.0)

> **Sharing a note with a reviewer is now something you do on purpose.** Before 0.26.0, any open note on a public page was readable by anyone holding a review link - your own working notes included. Notes are now internal by default and reach a reviewer only when you tick **Visible to client reviewers** on the note. The check fails closed, so **every note written before you upgraded is invisible to review links** until you share it deliberately.

Tick the box on the front-end panel's More drawer or in the repository's edit panel. A shared note carries a **Client visible** badge in the front-end list, on the edit screen and in the repository table, and a **Client visible** column in the CSV export, so you can always tell at a glance what a client can read.

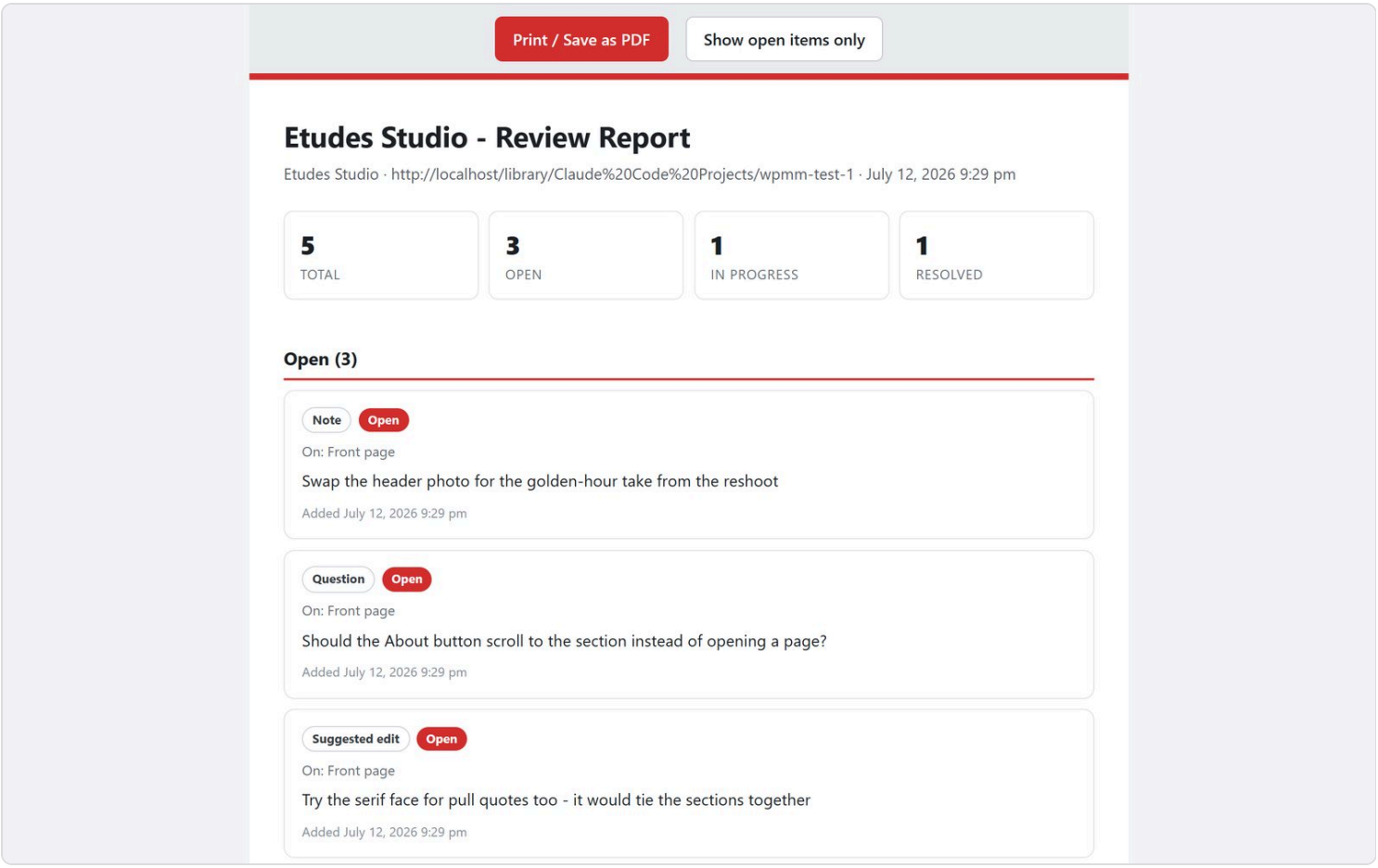
Reviewers see their own reports at any status, with the date the report was marked fixed. Before, reviewer reads were pinned to open notes, so a client's Resolved tab could never fill and a report you had fixed looked identical to one that never saved. A one-time migration on upgrade restores the flag on notes the client themselves filed through a review link, so their own feedback stays visible to the link that filed it. Notes old enough to predate the token stamp keep exactly the visibility they had before - open-only - rather than gaining the new behaviour.

Reviewers never see agent-queue notes, site-wide notes, or notes on drafts, private or pending posts. Those constraints were there before and still are; the visibility tick is an extra gate on top of them, never a replacement.

> **Two links on one site are not isolated from each other.** A note a client files through their link is client-visible by definition, so while it is open, any other review link on the same site can read it and the name typed on it. That has been true since review links shipped and is deliberate - a second reviewer at the same client picking up the thread is usually what you want. If you hand links to two clients who must not see each other's feedback, use two sites, or keep the second client's round until the first client's notes are resolved.

The client report

One click in the repository turns the notes into a printable report - totals, then every note grouped by status, ready for "Print / Save as PDF". Internal fields (assignees, agent queues, browser context) stay out; the report is written for the client's eyes.



The client report. The report settings let you set your own title, logo and accent colour and hide the Red Pen credit - white-label branding is free for everyone.

Red Pen Hub (optional)

If you run several projects, the free Red Pen Hub collects their notes onto one local board. Connect this site from Display settings in the repository (administrators only): paste the Hub's URL and connect token, and the site pushes its notes to your Hub - resolving on either side updates the other. The Hub, like Red Pen itself, is free. Ignore this section if you work one site at a time; nothing requires it.

Where your notes live

Notes are a private post type inside your own WordPress database, invisible to the front end and to search engines. Screenshots go to your uploads folder. Deactivating the plugin hides the overlay; your notes stay in the database until you delete them.

If something breaks

Symptom	Likely cause and fix
No Red Pen entry in the admin bar	Your user can't edit posts (Red Pen shows for editors and up), or the plugin isn't active on this site.
Overlay missing on a page	Dev Mode is off (check the admin-bar toggle), or that view is excluded under Display settings.
A pin doesn't show	The element it was pinned to no longer exists on the page - the note itself is still in the panel and repository.
The panel says a note could not be saved	The message gives the reason: the connection dropped, you were logged out of WordPress, the review link stopped working, or too many notes went in within a few minutes. What was typed stays in the box, so deal with the cause and add it again. A tab left open for more than a day fetches a fresh WordPress token and tries once more by itself.
A save failed and no message appeared	The site is on a version before 0.29.0. Those versions drew the panel's messages as white text with no background, so they were there but could not be read. Update the plugin.
"Could not take the screenshot"	The capture failed on that part of the page. Try a smaller area, or describe what you see in the note instead.
Display settings or the report branding are missing	Your account is not an administrator. Since 0.29.0 those settings are for administrators only, because they change things for the whole site, the Hub connection included. Everything else under Tools > Red Pen works the same for editors.
Client says the review link doesn't work	The link was revoked or expired, or it was mistyped - the full token is part of the URL. A link that has stopped working now tells the client so on the page. Generate a fresh one.
Client's panel is empty, or a note you expected them to see is missing	The note is internal. Since 0.26.0 a note reaches a review link only when **Visible to client reviewers** is ticked, and every note written before the upgrade starts internal. Tick the box on the notes you want shared.
Client can't see the note they filed	Their own reports are visible to them at any status. If one is missing, it was filed through a different review link - a note belongs to the link that wrote it.

The rest of the family

Red Pen also runs on Express apps, static sites, Blender and Ableton Live, with the Red Pen Hub collecting them onto one board. The surfaces are separate ports of one model rather than one codebase, so they do not all have the same features at the same time. The **Surface matrix** at `docs.redpen.tools/matrix.html` is the per-feature answer for which surface has what today.